

What's the Connection?

Using trauma-informed techniques can create a setting of psychological safety, leading to more accurate assessments, better outcomes, and greater trust.

What is Psychological Trauma?

Psychological trauma results from an event, series of events, or set of circumstances experienced **as physically or emotionally harmful** and that has **lasting negative** effects on the person's mental, physical, social, emotional, or spiritual well-being.

What are trauma responses?

People who have gone through trauma can respond to feelings of threat and danger based on **what seemed necessary** during trauma, or **what could stop it from happening again**. Trauma responses can be **automatic and not intentional** in the setting of **sympathetic nervous system activation**. Trauma responses can include:

- Fight: tension, expressing irritation or dissatisfaction
- Flight: avoiding dental care, no-shows, getting up and leaving the dental chair
- Freeze: not moving, not talking
- Fawn: undue compliance, not expressing needs until utterly overwhelmed



Why would dental care induce a trauma response?

Common dental care experiences like pain, close physical proximity, supine position, sense of physical restraint, or feelings of loss of control and vulnerability can remind patients of traumatic events. Abuse and assault often involve the face and head, leading to negative associations while receiving dental care. Avoiding dental care can be a trauma response that leads to a need for significant dental work down the road.

Clinical Excellence through Trauma- Informed Dentistry

For Dental Professionals



What is Trauma-Informed Dental Care?

Pursuing clinical excellence involves anticipating and responding to patient needs, toward improving their adherence to vital treatments. Trauma-informed dental care is a set of techniques and values that help retain and meet the needs of people with a history of trauma. Universal precautions for trauma can support patient-centered care whether or not the patient's trauma history is known.

How can I Learn More?

Being trauma-informed means embracing lifelong learning. There is more work to be done in the field to improve comprehensive responses to trauma and improve integration of healthcare sectors like dentistry, mental health, and primary care. You can start with the **Oral Health Recovery Collaborative** website, which contains information on research into the connection between oral health and mental health, including trauma-informed dental care at https://nschuman28.github.io/dental_care_project/index.html

Patient Resources

- The **988 Lifeline** is a free, confidential talk line available 24/7, 365 days a year. Whether people are facing mental health struggles, emotional distress, alcohol or drug use concerns, or just need to talk, the Lifeline is available.
 - You can call 988
 - You can also text or chat
 - Visit <https://988lifeline.org/>
- The **American Psychological Association** website has resources for patients on coping with traumatic events, depression, anger, anxiety, PTSD, and addiction at <https://www.apa.org/topics/trauma/healing-guide>

Examples of Trauma informed Care

- Center as much control with the patient as possible. Ask for sensory or positional preferences or sensitivities (e.g., “Is it ok if I put the chair back?”)
- One rule of thumb is to normalize, but not minimize, the patient’s experiences, and to treat them as the expert on their own lives and needs.
- Asking permission to touch, asking how to make the visit more comfortable, explaining how long each procedure will take, and transparency on treatment plan, procedures, and cost can each contribute to trauma-informed care.
- Casual, seemingly simple comments like “it’s been a while since we’ve seen you here” can be interpreted as judgmental; consider how statements could be interpreted by someone who overcame significant barriers to make the appointment in the first place.

Do I need to be a “trauma specialist” to treat patients who have trauma?

No. Dental professionals can use skills and strategies they already possess, such as expressing empathy, reflective listening, motivational interviewing, and de-escalation strategies if a patient displays a trauma response. Having mental health referral resources available on flyer/s or cards; referring the patient to their primary care provider; or consulting with their outside specialists can also help.

If a patient’s trauma comes up during a visit, how can I find the words to express empathy and understanding?

Practice makes perfect! Consider and write down phrases that feel natural to you, then try them out during patient care. Some sample phrasings include:

- I might not ever fully understand all that has happened to you, but I am here to help make your dental appointments more comfortable.
- Thank you for telling me about it. It is helpful to know that happened to you. Let’s work together to make your dental appointments comfortable for you.
- You can say as much or as little as you want. We can focus our discussion on how to make today’s visit more comfortable.
- We have resources for people who have gone through similar things. May I show you a flyer that lists some of the resources we know about?

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